

Varjak’s First Night Outside

Trembling with cold, he crept down from the wall into the alleyway below. The smell hit him like a fist. Oil, hot metal and something sharp that he had no name for filled his nose and made his eyes water. Shadows slipped and slid along the damp, dark brickwork. A sea of lights blinked and pulsed at the end of the street. He had imagined the Outside a thousand times. He had never imagined anything like this. He had not gone far when a shape dropped silently from the wall above. Then another.

“You lost?” said one of them. She was lean and fast-looking, with eyes like pale flames.

“No,” said Varjak. “I am looking for a dog.”

The two cats stared at each other. The first one started to laugh. “A dog?” she said. “You? Looking for a dog?”

Varjak didn’t answer. At the end of the alleyway, something vast was thundering along the road. Its eyes blazed white and its whole body shook with a sound like a hundred growls rolled into one. He pressed himself flat against the wall. “Is that one?” he said. “Is that what they call a dog?”

The two cats looked. The first one tilted her head. “That,” she said, “is a car.” She glanced at her friend, then back at Varjak, and when she spoke again her voice was a little gentler. “Dogs are different. Come on.”

He followed them deeper into the city, though his paws ached and his heart would not slow down. They turned left, then right, then down a long steep alley that smelled of rain and old stone. At the far end, in a patch of yellow lamplight, something enormous lay very still.

Varjak stopped. The creature was bigger than anything he had ever seen in his life. It was huge and dark, with fur the texture of wire and teeth like white knives. A low sound came from deep inside its chest. Not quite a growl. Something worse.

“That,” said the first cat quietly, “is a dog.”

Varjak crept forward a step. His legs had gone hollow and his claws scraped against the cobbles without him telling them to. The dog’s eyes opened. They were pale and cold, like two chips of ice. They fixed on Varjak and did not move.

“Are you looking for something, little cat?” the dog said.

Varjak swallowed. “I need your help,” he said. “My family are in danger.”

For a long moment the dog said nothing. Then the rough coat settled. The great head dropped slowly. Something in those pale eyes changed, like a fire going down to embers, and the voice that came out next was low and steady.

“Tell me what you need,” it said.

They had no time to make a plan. Something screeched from the shadows just as Varjak was about to speak. Five cats slid out of the darkness, their eyes glittering and their claws already unsheathed. Varjak had heard about Razor’s gang. They were the ones who ruled these streets.

“Run,” said the first cat.

Varjak stood his ground. He was afraid. He was outnumbered. He had been training for this moment his whole life. He felt the Way move through him, calm and steady, like water running over smooth stone. The gang moved fast, but Varjak moved faster. His friends fought beside him, and the gang scattered howling into the dark.

The alleyway was silent. Varjak stood in the lamplight and looked at his paws. He was still shaking. He had done it.

Annotation key — use four colours

- Colour 1: Setting and character description**
expanded noun phrases, sensory detail, thoughts and reactions
- Colour 2: Figurative language**
simile, alliteration, hyperbole, power of three
- Colour 3: Sentence structure**
fronted adverbials, subordinating conjunctions, short sentences
- Colour 4: Speech punctuation**
inverted commas, reporting clauses, action woven in

Annotation notes